war area from Palestine eastward managed from India by the Indian Government, both militarily and politically'.[15]

Unfortunately for Montagu and the government of India, there was little support in London for the suggestion. The Foreign Office argued that the 'feeling in Persia against India and Indian officials is traditional, and were the whole of the policy in Persia to be conducted from Simla that feeling would undoubtedly become aggravated'.[16] The War Office thought that handing control to India would be viewed by the Persian population as nothing less than a step towards the annexation of their country.[17] Curzon cut to the heart of the matter when he pointed out that while it might be irritating for India to not have greater control in Persia, 'it would be not only disagreeable but dangerous to have a Minister at Teheran [sic] who might be pursuing a policy inspired or dictated from Delhi, that did not fit in with the foreign policy of Downing Street'.[18] The supremacy of the Home government was ultimately indisputable. However, the consequences of refusing to allow India a greater say in Britain's affairs in Persia and elsewhere would mean that, very quickly after the armistice, the Indian government would look to roll back its commitments – both militarily and financially – to their pre-war standing. Although necessitated by economic concerns, perhaps India might have been more willing to delay retrenchment had it felt its efforts in this region were appreciated more by Whitehall.

While there was little support for granting the Indian government complete autonomy in southern Asia and the Middle East, the War Office and the Foreign Office certainly agreed that better coordination of policy was needed.[19] Persia appeared the most acute example of overlapping jurisdiction, but by 1918 there was a general realisation within the British government that its policy towards this region should be treated as a whole – that Egypt, Mesopotamia, Persia, Palestine, Arabia and the Caucasus, while representing varying levels of British involvement, were all inextricably linked by geography, religion and history, and that having one body to define, implement and co-ordinate policy across this area would considerably strengthen Britain's presence there.[20] This concept of unifying control was not necessarily a new one – the idea of a Near Eastern Viceroyalty or India-Middle East Empire had previously been floated by the